

FOR SUBS • CHAPTER 4

Ending well

LAST CHECKED 3 NOVEMBER 2026 • 7 MINUTES TO READ

Anyone can leave, pause or change the terms, on either side of the screen. A good ending is short, kind and final. A crisis is something else, and it needs people outside the game.

EVIDENCE ◆ Verified ◆ Reported ◆ Vivian's field notes

This chapter is not advice for your situation.

IN 30 SECONDS

01 A sub can leave or pause at any time, and a good dom accepts it right away.

02 One short message makes a clean ending. Chasing, begging and guilt don't.

03 A goodbye that hints at self-harm is a crisis. Call emergency services or a local helpline, and reach a person nearby.

04 A dom who's paid can't be the safety net for a sub in trouble.

05 Doms need pauses too, and a tool you can't quit is a warning sign.

YOU WILL LEARN

- ✓ How to leave, pause or end a session without damage.
- ✓ Which pressures to spot and refuse when you leave.
- ✓ How to cut down with a clean break and outside support.
- ✓ What to do when someone leaves in crisis.
- ✓ What a real exit looks like in a tool, and why doms burn out.

> *You don't owe me a reason, an apology or one last send. If you go, I hope you get the life you want. If you ever tell me you're in danger, I drop the character and send you to people who can help.*
>
> — VIVIAN

PART 01

You can leave, and you can pause

Subs leave. They're tempted by other doms, get bored or curious, or regret choices they made while aroused. Some stay a day, others a year, and in my experience few stay for many years. Some leave and come back many times. A dom can't force anyone to stay, only make staying more appealing, and the decision is always the sub's. ◆

Pausing is fine. When a sub says he's going downhill and wants to continue another day, accept it at once, and don't ask for an apology. ◆

V VIVIAN'S FIELD NOTES

In my experience everyone who runs a persona loses subs, big spenders included. They tend to drift away over months, mostly on good terms. A scene career has peaks. Accept that subs come and go, keep the ones who leave friendly, and don't measure yourself against anyone else.

◆

PART 02

What a good ending looks like

A clean exit

1. Say it in one line. Going silent is a way to cope, but a short message spares the other person the feeling of being ghosted.
2. Thank the other person if you want to. You don't have to.
3. Stop. Don't wait for permission, and don't explain more than you want to.
4. If you want a clean break, block the accounts you know, and ask the doms not to write.

A long silence is often read as an attempt to quit. The persona rule that fits here is never to chase: at most one short check-in with no invitation to come back, then the sub comes to her, and she doesn't follow up. A sub who has said he's quitting gets no message at all. ◆

TRY IT

A sub has been silent for two weeks

You're a dom, and a sub who wrote every day hasn't said anything for two weeks.

A Message him every day until he answers

Not this one. Chasing turns a silence into pressure.

B Ask a friend of his to plead your case

Not this one. A go-between after a silence is pressure with a friendly face.

C Send at most one short check-in with no invitation to return, then send nothing more and let him come back if he wants

The right answer. Respecting the silence keeps the exit safe for both sides.

PART 03

When someone leaves, and the pressure to stay

A sub who leaves may get an appeal: apologies, promises to change, begging, questions about why, or a friendly third party sent to plead. For a sub, answering an appeal is optional, and a firm no ends it. For a dom, begging and go-betweens slide into pressure, so once a sub holds firm, she stops. ◆

When you leave

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

01 *"Go ahead, do what you like, I will just be sad"*

THE COUNTER

Permission with a hidden cost. Ask for a plain yes or no, and talk about the need behind your request.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

02 *Anger, then disappointment, then conditional forgiveness*

THE COUNTER

Her feelings aren't a bill. A healthy bond survives a boundary.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

03 *An invitation to get attached, then an offer of ownership*

THE COUNTER

A feeling turned into something that keeps you from leaving. Leaving stays a free choice.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

04 *"If you leave, I quit", "there is no point without you"*

THE COUNTER

A trope between two people playing. Aimed at a paying sub, it's a way to keep him, and keeping her motivated is never your job.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

05 *A deadline, a full written account of what you did, and a threat to end all contact*

THE COUNTER

This piles on guilt and takes away your choice. Ask to pause, and bring in someone you trust before you agree to anything.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

06 *“Bring your doubts to me first, not to others”*

THE COUNTER

It cuts you off from outside views. Talk to someone you trust.

Press reports describe pressure lines that tie love to selling a car or a house. ◆

These patterns show up right when a sub is trying to protect himself. Notice them, and answer once. A dom who writes “take your time, no need to explain” is acting in the interest of both sides. ◆

TRY IT

Saying a plain no

Tap every message that shows a red flag. There are two.

Example conversation. Invented for this exercise.

THEM

I thought you were different from the others. I am so hurt.

Red flag 1. Putting her hurt in front of your boundary makes you responsible for her feelings.

YOU

I'm stopping for now. I wish you well.

THEM

Just one more time, to say goodbye properly.

Red flag 2. The exit is made to cost one more send.

YOU

No. Goodbye.

PART 04

If you want to cut down

The usual cycle is arousal and a wish to pay, a send, heavy guilt, hiding it, and a return once things feel calm. Hiding adds a second problem on top of the first.

- A blog post describes spending hidden from a partner as a risk factor.

The cycle

1. **Step 1**

   Arousal, and a wish to pay.

2. **Step 2**

   The send.

3. **Step 3**

   Guilt.

4. **Step 4**

   Hiding it.

5. **Step 5**

   A calm stretch, then step 1 again.

- A clean break is a real tool: block the doms you know, and ask them not to write.
- Counting the weeks since your last send is a useful way to track progress.
- Tell someone you trust soon after a send, and don't wait.
- Help works best from someone who earns nothing from you.

A dom who offers to help you quit earns from your spending, so her offer comes with a conflict of interest. Tapering with the same dom, or moving to a "better" dom, keeps the money in the same circle and leaves the dependence where it was. Cutting down is your decision and, if compulsion is involved, a job for outside support. See The spiral.

PART 05

When someone leaves in crisis

A goodbye that hints at self-harm is a crisis. The same goes for a sub deep in debt who says he sees no future. A thank-you at the end doesn't prove the person is safe. ◆ An academic survey of findommes reports that they faced clients' verbal aggression and, in some cases, suicidal tendencies. ◆

RED FLAGS

When a goodbye is a crisis

- He says he's hurting himself, or wants to die.
- He says goodbye in a way that hints at ending his life.
- He's deep in debt and sees no future.

Counter. Treat it as real. Drop the persona and the argument. Ask him to contact emergency services or a local helpline, and a person who's physically near him.

If someone tells you they may hurt themselves

1. Stop the scene and the argument. Drop the character and write plainly.
2. Ask whether he's safe right now, and listen.
3. If he's in danger, urge him to call his country's emergency number now. Otherwise urge him to call a local helpline, listed in Where to get help.
4. Ask him to reach a person who's physically near, and to stay with that person.
5. If you believe the danger is immediate and you know where he is, contact the emergency services for that place. If you're in another country or don't know where he is, a call may not go through. Use the platform's self-harm report tool, look up that country's police line on an official site, and don't promise help you can't give.
6. Stay calm. Don't make him responsible for your feelings, and don't argue about money or the scene.
7. You're not a therapist, and you shouldn't carry this alone. Tell someone you trust who knows you.
8. Ask for nothing afterwards, and point him to outside help for the longer road. See When a sub is in trouble.

A dom is paid by the same sub, so she can't be his safety net. A dom who earns from him can stop, listen, ask for nothing more and point him to outside help.

- If this is you, and you're the one in danger, call your emergency number or a helpline now, tell someone near you, and send no money tonight.

Free, confidential helplines exist in most countries.

Find a helpline →

PART 06

Tools, pauses and the dom side

Two kinds of exit

	A tool you can leave	A tool built to keep you
Stop	One click, working in every state	A locked switch, or a paid exit
Removal	Easy, and free	Hard, or framed as a betrayal
Total	Always visible	Hidden or vague
After the stop	Nothing happens	Messages, guilt or a “last chance”

A tool you can’t quit is a warning sign, which is why a quick exit, a safe word and a stop that works at once belong in the design. Safe design often means earning less.

V

VIVIAN'S FIELD NOTES

The work has no closing time. For many people it sits beside a day job, with heavy emotional labour and little rest. Burnout is real. Stop rushing, stop beating yourself up, and step away from the screen. After a painful loss, remove the person, and read the timeline from a separate account so triggers don't reach you.

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Depending on a few people is fragile, because a main supporter can leave overnight. Two or three real relationships soften the damage, and a sub who announces he's leaving hurts less than one who vanishes. Free chats and unpaid sessions lead to exhaustion, and a second dom who helps for free should get something back. ◆

Save hard conversations for when both people are rested and sober. Someone tired or drinking can't answer or listen properly, and arguments held in that state tend to get worse. ◆

Words for an ending

A clean exit

One short message, then stop. ◆

A pause

A rest without apology, on either side. ◆

A crisis

A goodbye that hints at self-harm. Call emergency services or a helpline. ◆

A conflict of interest

A dom paid by the sub can’t be the person who helps him quit. ◆

TRY IT

Check yourself

QUESTION 1 OF 3

A sub says goodbye in a way that hints at ending his life. What do you do?

- ◯ Argue about the money
- ◯ Drop the persona, urge emergency services or a helpline, and a person nearby
- ◯ Reply with a long plea and wait

Answer. Drop the persona, urge emergency services or a helpline, and a person nearby. It's a crisis. Outside help matters more than the scene.

QUESTION 2 OF 3

A sub asks to pause for a day. What should a dom do?

- ◯ Accept at once and ask for no apology
- ◯ Ask him to explain at length
- ◯ Remind him what she's done for him

Answer. Accept at once and ask for no apology. Pausing is fine, and guilt when someone leaves is pressure.

QUESTION 3 OF 3

Who is the right person to help a sub taper his spending?

- ◯ The dom he sends to
- ◯ A “better” dom
- ◯ Someone who earns nothing from him

Answer. Someone who earns nothing from him. A paid person has a conflict of interest, and moving the money keeps the loop going.

REMEMBER IT

- ♥ You can leave or pause, and you don’t owe a reason.
- ♥ One short message makes a clean ending.
- ♥ Never chase, beg or send a go-between.
- ♥ A goodbye that hints at self-harm is a crisis. Call emergency services or a helpline, and reach a person nearby.
- ♥ A paid dom can’t be the safety net.

SOURCES AND EVIDENCE

Check it

Every claim with its evidence level and its sources.

EVIDENCE LEVELS

◆	Checked against the original source.
◆	Stated by a serious secondary source read in full.
◆	Widely said in the scene; no document proves it.
◆	First-hand experience, not a study.
◆	Plausible, not proven yet.

01 They're tempted by other doms, get bored or curious, or regret choices they made while aroused.

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02 Some stay a day, others a year, and in my experience few stay for many years.

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03 Some leave and come back many times.

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04 A dom can't force anyone to stay, only make staying more appealing, and the decision is always the sub's.

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09 A sub who has said he's quitting gets no message at all.

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12 For a dom, begging and go-betweens slide into pressure, so once a sub holds firm, she stops.

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13 Press reports describe pressure lines that tie love to selling a car or a house.

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[a former participant] has seen men left broke and hungry from 'paying women to talk to them' (https://www.sbs.com.au/news/the-feed/article/the-online-kink-thats-leaving-some-men-homeless-bankrupt-and-normalising-suffering/vocm5xt30)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20251123124217/https://www.sbs.com.au/news/the-feed/article/the-online-kink-thats-leaving-some-men-homeless-bankrupt-and-normalising-suffering/vocm5xt30)

Accessed 3 November 2026

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15 A dom who writes “take your time, no need to explain” is acting in the interest of both sides.

16 The usual cycle is arousal and a wish to pay, a send, heavy guilt, hiding it, and a return once things feel calm.

17 Hiding adds a second problem on top of the first.

18 A blog post describes spending hidden from a partner as a risk factor.

The Psychology of Financial Dominatrixes (blog post) (https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/in-excess/201612/the-psychology-financial-dominatrixes)

Accessed 3 November 2026

19 A clean break is a real tool: block the doms you know, and ask them not to write.

20 Counting the weeks since your last send is a useful way to track progress.

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26 The same goes for a sub deep in debt who says he sees no future.

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28 An academic survey of findommes reports that they faced clients' verbal aggression and, in some cases, suicidal tendencies.

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Findommes, Cybermediated Sex Work, and Rinsing (McCracken and Brooks-Gordon, Sexuality Research and Social Policy 18(4), 837-854, DOI 10.1007/s13178-021-00609-3) (https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/PMC8418458/fullTextXML)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20261016030740/https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8418458/)

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38 Someone tired or drinking can't answer or listen properly, and arguments held in that state tend to get worse.

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39 One short message, then stop.

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40 A rest without apology, on either side.

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41 Call emergency services or a helpline.

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42 A dom paid by the sub can’t be the person who helps him quit.

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Free, confidential helplines exist in most countries.

Find a helpline →

The Drawn Ledger 18+

Nothing here is financial, legal or medical advice for your situation.